

Pitcher plant



*One species of bat
uses pitcher plants
to sleep in!*

Pitcher is an old word for “jug”, which is a clue to how this strange plant feeds. Its leaves make tall tubes, with liquid in the bottom. Inside the sides are slippery. When an insect, such as a moth, lands to drink the plant’s sweet nectar, it skids and falls in. The liquid is a deadly pool, which digests the meal, like the juices in our stomach. The biggest pitcher plants have traps deep enough to swallow a frog or mouse. They eat everything except its skeleton!

A mouse-like animal called a tree shrew visits pitcher plants to lick their nectar. Afterwards, it uses the plants as a toilet! The plants don’t mind, because the shrew poo is extra food!